

compete with the regular World Cup, believes Sundar Raman, managing director of media buying agency Mindshare. It is estimated that the T20 World Cup has garnered Rs 150 crore from broadcast advertising, of which Rs 120 crore has come from India. Worldwide distribution revenues would account for Rs 100 crore and ground sponsorships would add up to another Rs 80 crore and ticket sales to Rs 8 crore. In comparison, regular ICC World Cup revenues stand at Rs 700 crore. Over time, evidently, T20 will command a premium over the old World Cup, as 51 matches are a long haul for broadcasters and ICC.

But you don't necessarily need deep pockets to make your presence felt in cricket. Given that ESPN, the

bottom after India's disastrous performance at the ICC World Cup in April where advertisers and sponsors suffered losses to the tune of Rs 500 crore after India's early exit from the event.

Non-traditional brands took the opportunity to enter the cricket advertising market at much lower costs. After World Cup rates, which were between Rs 2.5 and Rs 3.5 lakh per 10 seconds, crashed in May, Kishore Biyani's Future Group could pick up a tournament title for a throwaway Rs 2.5 crore. Says Biyani: "We entered cricket when it was cheap and the rates had crashed. We have committed to spend Rs 150 crore for roughly 55 games over the next three years. Our youthful brands will go well with the T20 format and once the schedule is out, we will associate with that too."

Of the Rs 6,000-crore television advertising market in India, cricket accounts for Rs 700 crore. Currently growing at 12 per cent year on year, it can ratchet up faster growth as the domestic T20 leagues kick off in India too. With T20 hitting home with the Indian audience, more money is likely to flow into the format. Both BCCI and the Zee's Indian Cricket League (ICL) are gearing up to cash in on this format already.

With ICL in the final stages of finalising its six-city leagues, BCCI, too, has announced its plans to launch eight domestic teams city-wise. Both plan to follow the franchisee model wherein companies will own the teams. While BCCI's asking price of \$50 million for 10 years is pinching advertisers, India's win may jack up rates further. Says Ashish Kaul, executive vice-president, Essel Group: "The new format gives an opportunity to expand the market. With new viewers, a new breed of advertisers is looking at investing in cricket."

Though both BCCI and ICL claim that corporates are queuing up to invest in the teams, advertisers are still playing it safe by waiting and watching. But there is no doubt that with the stupendous success of the T20 World Cup, corporate investment in domestic leagues is an idea whose time has come.

by Malini Bhupta

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◀ M.S. DHONI, INDIA CAPTAIN

late terms. "RP was the difference," says Pakistani captain Shoaib Malik, "he is much quicker and more in control of his line and length." Singh, described by Prasad as a "thinker", has gone from being first change on the England tour to opening bowler in T20.

The bowler from Rae Bareilly says, "When you are with the team, you get back-up support, you bowl to the best batsmen and you know where you stand. Practice of that quality feeds into confidence in a match." Prasad and the bowlers sat down and discussed scenarios, with the coach putting the questions and the bowlers supplying their answers. In the World T20, when the scenarios came at the bowlers in a rising tide, the Indians could cope.

As India pulled one tight game after another, Dhoni's captaincy began to be noticed. He now has "presence" in the dressing room. He has gone from one of the boys to the boss in three seasons, but with little distance between himself and his colleagues. He has kept communication open with even the most unheralded cricketer in his squad. "I don't think any other Indian captain would have given the ball to Joginder in the semi-final against Australia," says a team member. In the final, when the medium pacer sent down a horrifying wide on the first ball of the last over with 13 to get, Dhoni jogged down the length of the pitch to put his arm around the shaky bowler's shoulders.

Dhoni will be tested more severely but has shown a healthy appetite for a scrap. "We just wanted to tell everyone that if you want a verbal war, we are ready for it," he says. Other than Andrew Flintoff's "I'll cut your throat" to Yuvraj, not all the verbal wars took place in the middle. The T20 dugout became the location of pre-match jousting, unseen by the cameras, busy honing in on the dancing girls.

It gave the Indians the best view of an opposition going into meltdown.



official telecast partner for the T20 World Cup, did not want to take a risk with the advertising inventory, it sold 80 per cent of it before the tournament began. Unlike the previous World Cup, inventory was sold *a la carte* and not just in bulk packages. So advertisers could do cherry picking. And those who came in late paid up to Rs 5.5 lakh for a 10-second slot on the day of the Indo-Pak finals.

Even though the detailed viewership figures are not out yet, sponsors and early-bird advertisers are laughing their way to the bank as T20 has revived the nation's interest in cricket, which had touched rock